crossed over to India within a month 'unable to bear the reported hostility of the new Mujahideen rulers in Afghanistan'.[122] The second closure happened between February and September 1993, when fighting broke out between Hekmatyar and other Mujahideen factions including Mohaqiq's Hazara dominated *Hizb-e-Wahdat*, the *Jamiat-e-Islami*, and Dostum's newly created *Jumbish-e-Milli*. Pakistan and Saudi Arabia brokered what was called the March accord in 1993 between the fighting factions as they agreed to a ceasefire until the next elections at the end of 1994.[123] The third, and penultimate time India packed up its mission was between January 1994 and 3 May 1995, when Dostum and Hekmatyar joined hands briefly to oust Rabbani and Mohaqiq, and the Taliban emerged as a player on the Afghan stage.[124] Regardless, under the conciliators' influence, India maintained robust links with the Rabbani government, hosted Afghan leaders, continued distributing aid throughout this period via the UN, and reopened its embassy as soon as it could. What was different with the Taliban was India's decision to keep its embassy shut (and this had to do with the rise of the partisans).

Though the conciliators were in agreement with their detractors that the Taliban was being sponsored by the ISI, they did not see the Taliban through an Islamist lens or as necessarily being a proxy force for Pakistani agencies despite the former's dependence on the latter. For Dixit, writing in 1996, the Taliban was a student movement primarily reflecting Pashtun interests with most of its recruits coming from the tribal areas of Pakistan.[125] While Dixit was aware of the problems associated with opening channels with the Taliban, he stated,

> to think that India can play a direct mediatory or intervening role in this violence-ridden situation is impracticable and unfeasible ... In the coming three to five years, it would be sufficient if India managed to maintain contact with all groups in Afghanistan and joined hands with other neighbouring countries which are genuinely interested in pacifying and normalising the situation in that country.[126]

India did not maintain contact with all Afghan factions, and instead demonised the Taliban.

Did Najibullah's murder by the Taliban make conciliation an unattractive option in 1996? Though it is true that the event tipped the balance against the conciliators, their fundamental beliefs remained robust and continued to sow doubt about India's anti-Taliban, anti-Pakistan partisanship. In October 1996,